

Teaching in the minefield of arbitrariness



Photo: Adrian Wyld The Canadian Press "It is urgent that higher education institutions adopt a clear policy to protect the integrity of knowledge and its conveyors, and this must include, among other things, the recognition of the right to reasonable disagreement and that of the principle of charity ", say the signatories.

Murielle Chapuis and Mathieu Gauthier *

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https://www.ledevoir.com/opinion/idees/588101/enseigner-dans-le-champ-mine-de-l-arbitraire?fbclid=IwAR3IzYNVK0S0wiCcLly2f_b_asgEOmpzfccfsDRlbi_x-6OvObhQbPbKPt4

By publicly and unilaterally condemning the use of the word "nigger" in class by a professor from the Faculty of Arts at the University of Ottawa, and by suspending her, not only did Dean Kevin Kee attack to the freedom of teaching of higher education professors on its campus, but it has also abused a power of coercion that goes against knowledge and the dissemination of knowledge.

In the October 2 press release sent to the Ottawa University community, Mr. Kee bluntly said, "This language was offensive and it is totally unacceptable to use it in our classrooms as well as on our campus. [...] Everyone at the University of Ottawa has the right to an environment free from discrimination and harassment, and the right to be treated with dignity and respect. "

Confusion

Yet there is obvious confusion here. In reaction to the treatment of their colleague, more than thirty professors from the University of Ottawa recalled in a letter the importance of distinguishing between racism on campus, which must obviously be denounced, and the role of university education, which consists of nourishing reflection and developing critical thinking. The students and the dean were not able to make these distinctions and make a reasonable judgment on the incident, recognizing the teaching context and the professor's intention.

Now that more and more teachers are trying to diversify the content of their courses, how can we without this word teach the very relevant film *I Am Not Your Negro*, by Raoul Peck, or Leopold's artistic trend of negritude? Sédar Senghor and Aimé Césaire? How to refer to the classic work of Pierre Vallières, explain the multiple meanings of " Speak white " in Michèle Lalonde's poem, evoke the universe of Toni Morrison or the work of Dany Laferrière How to make love with a nigger without tiring, an eminently satirical book?

After Wendy Mesley of the CBC and Professor Catherine Russell of Concordia University, this is the third time that the use and mention of words has been confused. In the present case, there is also another confusion, that which prevails between an act of aggression and an act of subversion. To teach the "subversive resignification" of words, which Professor Verushka Lieutenant-Duval was doing, it is still necessary to be able to mention them.

To teach a whole section of the arts, culture, politics and society, you need to have historical and necessary concepts at your disposal. It is also inevitable that in some courses the complex issues of the human condition can sometimes collide. But, as Alain Deneault expressed it in his article "Cabale au Canada" published in *Le Monde diplomatique* : "The unleashing of passions collectively deprives minds of a space conducive to creative, hypothetical, uncertain positions, even if it means sometimes wandering. . Dean Kee should have reaffirmed the importance of the arts and humanities. He would thus have shown pedagogy by reminding students that by wanting to prohibit words, we also deprive ourselves of access to different knowledge.

Ethics of "governance"?

[In the letter "We must defend the academic freedom of academics" published in February 2019](#) in *Le Devoir*, 450 professors from here and elsewhere already denounced this form of slippage. They criticized a new trend present in the "governance" of higher education establishments which, taking up the vertical conception of power resulting from the private model, subordinates the freedom of education to the arbitrariness of deans or rectors. This is exactly what concerns us here.

Whatever some may say, it is possible to denounce racism while requiring that the mention of the term hated be sometimes valid and received appropriately in a teaching context. Some would say that it is above all necessary to demand more diversity among teachers and to actively work to understand the reasons why some people feel aggrieved during such incidents. Without a doubt, but the fight for diversity and against racism should go hand in hand with the free flow of ideas and knowledge.

The University of Ottawa is on the wrong target. We do not tackle the problem of racism by punishing and prohibiting the teaching of words, works and authors who, on the contrary, reveal it and explicitly combat it.

As Dany Laferrière publicly argued in an interview for France Culture very recently, it is not the word that must be eliminated, but the intention in use: "In the mouth of a white man, n ' anyone can use it. We know when we are insulted, when someone uses a word to humiliate or crush you. We also know when it's another job. "

It is urgent that higher education institutions adopt a clear policy to protect the integrity of knowledge and its conveyors, and this must include, among other things, the recognition of the right to reasonable disagreement and that of the principle of charity. The social context and clientelism cannot prevail over knowledge and its dissemination. We are waiting for the President and Dean of the Faculty of Arts at the University of Ottawa to publicly correct this grave precedent which attacks the freedom of education head-on, and which undermines the field of knowledge and research.

[* This text is signed by nearly 600 professors and teachers](#)